

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN SEYCHELLES

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide is built around the Seychelles' distinctive lever — a mobilised public defending a protected place, and a parliament whose ratification a project needs and can be made to withhold — and it names the bodies and tools you'll meet (the EIA and environmental authorisation, the National Assembly's ratification, protected-area and World Heritage status, the courts) in plain words the first time.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

On the remote island of **Assumption**, some eleven hundred kilometres from Mahé and close to **Aldabra** — one of the largest atolls on Earth, a **World Heritage Site** and home to the world's largest population of giant tortoises — a foreign power was to build a **military base** under a signed twenty-year agreement, funded and part-run from abroad. On paper it looked settled, signed at the highest level. But Seychellois citizens, environmental organisations, and much of the public opposed it — out of genuine fear for the pristine environment near Aldabra, and out of concern for the country's sovereignty. They protested. The concerns reached the **World Heritage authorities**. And, decisively, the opposition that held a majority in the **National Assembly** made plain it **would not ratify** the agreement — and so the government, unable to command the votes, could not carry it through. The deal was revised, left unrepresented, and at length declared dead. The base was not built; Seychelles chose to build a smaller facility of its own instead. A signed agreement backed by a powerful foreign partner was stopped by a mobilised public and a parliament that refused.

The Seychellois citizens and the National Assembly that refused to ratify the Assumption base drew on a toolkit, and one lever a small parliamentary democracy makes unusually potent. A project needs an **EIA and environmental authorisation**. **Protected-area and World Heritage status** carry strong protection and international scrutiny — the threat to a pristine place near Aldabra supplied the cause and the international eye. The **courts** are open; protest, petition, and litigation are lawful. And — the decisive lever — many projects and agreements of consequence need the **National Assembly's ratification or approval**, which a parliament can withhold, as it did here. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. The decisive lever — a **parliament that would not ratify** — was available because the opposition held the Assembly; where a government controls the legislature, that lever is weaker, and the **ballot box** becomes part of the fight. The opposition was of **mixed motives** — genuine environmental protection *and* national sovereignty and geopolitics — and honesty requires naming both. And the outcome had **nuances**: the base was blocked, but the agreement lingered in diplomatic language, and a foreign surveillance presence did not vanish overnight. So judge success by whether the destructive project is stopped, not by whether every trace disappears at once.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A big project looks unstoppable, but it's a chain of approvals, and a chain breaks at its weakest link. A large Seychellois project needs its **EIA and authorisation**; if it touches a **protected or World Heritage place**, it runs into protection and international scrutiny; it can be challenged in the **courts**; and, crucially, if it needs the **National Assembly's ratification**, a parliament can refuse it. Every one of those is a link you can grab — and the parliamentary refusal is the one that stopped the base. **Find the one closest to your hand and**

pull.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend a year on this, work out your real situation:

- **If the project needs the Assembly's ratification, that is your sharpest lever** — a parliament that refuses can halt even a signed deal.
- **If it threatens a protected or World Heritage place, that status and the international eye are strong levers.**
- **If the EIA or authorisation is defective, the process and the courts are real grounds.**
- **If the government controls the Assembly, the parliamentary lever is weaker** — then the environmental, international, and court levers carry more, and the ballot box becomes part of the fight.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **defend the place, mobilise the public, draw the world's eye, and turn the parliament** — the Assumption template — and **run every lever together**, with the honest caution that the decisive one needs a parliament willing to refuse. That's how the base was stopped.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a project moves, and who's watching.

Who Actually Decides

A project needs an **EIA and environmental authorisation** from the environment authority. **Protected areas** and **World Heritage sites** (like Aldabra) carry strong protection and draw international scrutiny. The government negotiates and signs agreements — but agreements of consequence often need **ratification or approval by the National Assembly**, which can withhold it. The **courts** review the legality of decisions. Know which decision — executive, parliamentary, or judicial — you can reach, and aim there.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The EIA and authorisation. The project needs its assessment and authorisation. *Your opening:* take part, put your objections on the record, and attack the assessment's flaws.

The agreement and ratification. A major agreement is signed, then needs the **Assembly's ratification**. *Your opening — the decisive one:* turn the parliament against ratification, so the government cannot carry it through.

The protected place. *Your opening:* invoke the protected-area or World Heritage status, and the international bodies that watch it.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things. **Who's behind it and who owns them** — including any foreign power or investor, whose reputation and the sovereignty concern you can raise. **What approval it needs** — the authorisation, and above all any **Assembly ratification**: whatever it needs is where you can stop it. **What protected place it touches** — because that status and the international eye are strong levers.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. The **environment authority** runs the EIA and authorisation. The **National Assembly** must ratify major agreements — and can refuse. The **World Heritage and international bodies** watch protected sites like Aldabra. The **courts** review decisions. And Seychelles' **environmental organisations, a mobilised public, and a free press** are the forces that reach furthest — the coalition that stopped the base.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises. What most moves them: whether the Assembly's ratification is needed and refusable, whether a protected place is engaged, and how the parliament is composed.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Objections in the EIA	15–35%	during assessment	low	On record; conditions or a redo
Protected-area / World Heritage lever	30–55%	varies	low	International scrutiny; project constrained
Court challenge (authorisation)	25–50%	months–yr	mod	Authorisation quashed; process ordered
Public mobilisation + international attention	30–55%	months–yr	low	Pressure; the world's eye
Turn the National Assembly against ratification	40–65%	weeks–months	low	Signed deal halted (Assumption)
Everything together (ratification needed, protected place, opposition Assembly)	45–70%	months–2 yr	mod	Project stopped, deal killed
Everything together (government controls Assembly)	20–45%	months–2 yr	mod	Delayed; constrained; fought at the ballot box

The lever that moves the needle most is **turning the National Assembly against ratification**, backed by public mobilisation, the protected-place status, and international attention. Assumption shows the ceiling (a signed foreign-backed base killed) and the honest floor (it needed an opposition-held Assembly, and a foreign presence lingered). So aim for a project stopped, a deal killed, a place protected, and delay — and where the parliamentary lever is weak, fight on the other ground.

On cost: mobilising, objecting, and campaigning are cheap; and the parliamentary lever, where available, costs nothing but the votes. The great strength is a small parliamentary democracy's power to withhold approval — and the honest caution is that this depends on who holds the Assembly, so the ballot box is part of the fight.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the project" is weak. Being specific — this ratification, this protected place, this defective authorisation — is strong. Answer five questions in writing.

1. What is it, and who's behind it? Name the project, the company or foreign power, and its backers.

2. Where is it, and what does it touch? Map it over **protected areas, World Heritage sites, reefs, and pristine coast. A protected or World Heritage place is your sharpest environmental lever** — Assumption's proximity to Aldabra drew the world's eye.

3. What approval does it need — and does it need the Assembly? An EIA and authorisation? A signed agreement needing **ratification**? The ratification is often the decisive lever.

4. How is the parliament composed? Does the opposition — or a coalition — hold enough to refuse ratification? This decides how strong the parliamentary lever is.

5. Who's your coalition, and what's the public mood? Environmental organisations, citizens, and the concerns — environmental and sovereign — that move people. Assumption joined a threatened treasure to a mobilised public.

What this looks like in real life. A government signs a foreign-backed project touching a pristine, protected place, needing the Assembly's ratification. The five questions yield: a foreign power and its backers; a protected/World Heritage place at stake (the environmental lever and the international eye); an authorisation and a ratification needed; a parliament that might refuse; and a public to mobilise. That's the Assumption pattern — defend the place, mobilise the public, draw the world's eye, and turn the parliament.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a community that can fight and one that can't is proof. Build it in three layers.

Layer one: the paper trail. Get the documents the project rests on — the agreement, the EIA and authorisation, the protected-area and World Heritage status, the ratification requirement. Then read them for flaws — an understated impact on a protected place, a deal made with little openness, an authorisation on a thin assessment.

Layer two: the ground truth. Dated, located photographs and video of the protected place, the reefs, and the coast — baseline images most of all — and the testimony of those who know and value it. Marshal the science on what the World Heritage or protected place would suffer.

Layer three: the map of the protected place and the harm. Lay the project over the protected area, the World Heritage site, and the coast, so the threat to a treasured place is undeniable — the case that moves the public, the parliament, and the international bodies. Walking into the Assembly, the courts, or the world with the agreement, the science, and that map is what makes them act.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The agreement, the EIA and authorisation, the protected-area and World Heritage status, the ratification requirement** — from the government, the environment authority, and the Assembly.
- **The parliament's composition** — who can refuse ratification.
- **Ownership and backing** — the company or foreign power.
- **The place-and-harm map** — the protected area, the World Heritage site, and the coast, laid over the project.
- **Dated site evidence, science, and named testimony** — photographs marked with date and place, and the voices of those who value the place.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; a mobilised public and a turnable parliament give you power — the Assumption model. Build in four moves.

Start with a broad coalition around the place. Environmental organisations, citizens, and all who treasure the threatened place — Assumption joined the defence of a World Heritage treasure to a broad public unease.

Name the concerns honestly — environmental and sovereign. Assumption's opposition was of mixed motives: the pristine environment near Aldabra *and* the nation's sovereignty. An honest campaign acknowledges both, and can draw strength from both, rather than pretending one was the whole.

Work the parliament — and, where needed, the ballot box. The decisive lever is the **Assembly's refusal to ratify**. Make the case to the members, build the public pressure that moves them, and — where the government controls the Assembly — carry the fight toward the ballot box, because the parliamentary lever is decided there.

Build to last, and draw the world's eye. Seychellois fights can run for a while, and outcomes can be gradual. Build clear roles, a secure archive, a way to decide together, a plan for the toll — and cultivate the international attention (World Heritage bodies, global media) that a small nation's fight for a pristine place can command.

STEP 4: LEGAL, PARLIAMENTARY & INTERNATIONAL LEVERS

The Seychelles' sharpest lever is the parliament, backed by the protected place, the international eye, and the courts.

Turn the Parliament Against Ratification — the Decisive Lever

The route that stopped Assumption: where a project or agreement needs the **National Assembly's ratification or approval**, turn the parliament against it. Make the case to the members, marshal the public pressure and the environmental and sovereignty concerns, and a parliament that **refuses to ratify** halts a project a government has already signed, however powerful its backers. This is the one lever a small parliamentary democracy makes unusually potent — with the honest caution that it needs a parliament willing to refuse.

The Protected Place and the International Eye

Invoke the **protected-area or World Heritage status** (as Assumption invoked Aldabra's), and draw the **international bodies** — the World Heritage authorities, global conservation networks — whose scrutiny a government cannot ignore. This supplies the cause and the weight behind the parliamentary and public pressure.

The EIA and the Courts

Take part in the **EIA**, attack a defective authorisation, and — where the process or the law is breached — challenge it in the **courts**. Where the parliamentary lever is weak (a government-controlled Assembly), these carry more of the fight.

The Honest Limits

Straight talk: the parliamentary lever is powerful but depends on who holds the Assembly; the motives in such fights are often mixed; and the outcome can be a gradual shelving rather than a clean cancellation, with a foreign presence lingering. So use the strong tools — the parliament, the protected place, the international eye, the EIA and courts — and count a project stopped, a deal killed, a place protected, and delay as wins, judging success by whether the destructive project is stopped.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

Ratification becomes the choke point. Not "we oppose the base" but *"this agreement needs the Assembly's ratification — and the Assembly should refuse it."*

A protected place becomes an international cause. *"This threatens a World Heritage treasure — the world is watching, and our nation must not shame it."*

Secrecy and sovereignty become a public argument. *"A foreign-run project on our soil, signed with little openness — our sovereignty and our environment both at stake."*

A defective authorisation becomes a challenge. *"The assessment understated the harm to a protected place — the authorisation is unsound."*

Match it to the venue: the ratification to the Assembly; the protected place to the international bodies; the sovereignty and secrecy to the public; the defective authorisation to the courts.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In Seychelles, national and international attention is a powerful lever — a fight for a pristine, protected place near a World Heritage atoll can command the world's eye, and public pressure moves the parliament. A free press makes the media front central.

Lead with the place and the nation, not procedure. Not "the authorisation was defective" but "a foreign military base beside a World Heritage atoll, the last home of the giant tortoises — signed over our heads." Use your strongest material: the science on the protected place, dated photographs, the map, and the voices that value it.

Work several audiences at once. Local press and public mobilisation move the Assembly; international media and the World Heritage bodies supply the weight; and the sovereignty concern broadens the coalition. Make it easy: captioned photos, accurate summaries, a map, strong interviews.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — one exaggeration can discredit everything. And keep the coalition honest about its mixed motives, and let it shape the story together.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; keep a copy of everything.

8A — Information request (to the government / environment authority).

Subject: Request for the agreement and authorisation — [project].

"We, citizens of [place], request the agreement, the EIA and environmental authorisation, and the protected-area/World Heritage status for [project] at [location]. [Contact.]"

8B — Objection in the EIA.

Subject: Objection — [project].

"We, citizens of [place], object to [project]: [it threatens a protected/World Heritage place; the assessment understates the harm]. We ask that authorisation be refused. [Attach evidence.]"

8C — To members of the National Assembly.

Subject: We ask you to refuse ratification of [project/agreement].

"We, citizens of [place], ask you not to ratify [the agreement for project], which threatens [a protected/World Heritage place] and [our sovereignty], and was made with little openness. As with Assumption, the Assembly's refusal can stop it. [Attach evidence.]"

8D — To the World Heritage / international bodies.

Subject: Threat to [protected/World Heritage place] — [project].

"We report that [project] at [location] threatens [the protected/World Heritage place], and ask you to take note and to act. [Attach evidence.]"

8E — To a lawyer (court challenge).

Subject: Possible challenge — [project] authorisation.

"Our community faces [project] threatening [a protected place], on [a defective authorisation]. We've gathered [the agreement, the science, photographs]. We ask your advice on challenging the authorisation. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8F — To the foreign power / backer.

Subject: Environmental and sovereignty concerns in [project].

"We are the community affected by [project] at [location]. It threatens [a World Heritage place] and raises grave concern over our environment and sovereignty, and faces public and parliamentary opposition. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8G — Letter to the press (national and international).

Subject: [Community] moves to protect [the place] from [project].

"Near [Aldabra / the protected place], [project] threatens [a pristine treasure] — signed over our heads. We can provide the science, photographs, a map and interviews. [Contact.]"

8H — Rallying the public.

Subject: We can protect this place — here's how.

"[Project] threatens [our pristine place] and [our sovereignty]. At Assumption, a mobilised public and a parliament that refused to ratify stopped a foreign-backed base. With the protected-place status, the world's eye, and the Assembly behind us, we have a real chance. Please join us. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean, do these six things, in order:

1. **Establish whether the project needs the Assembly's ratification — that's your sharpest lever.**
2. **Make the case to the members to refuse it (8C), and mobilise the public (8H).**
3. **Invoke the protected-area/World Heritage status and alert the international bodies (8D).**
4. **Object in the EIA (8B), and request the documents (8A).**
5. **Get a lawyer for a court challenge if the authorisation is defective (8E).**
6. **Draw the world's eye (8G) — and, where the parliament can't be turned, prepare the ballot box.**

Even lean, those six defend the place, mobilise the public, draw the world's eye, and turn the parliament — the Assumption template.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Seychelles' tools are real, but the field can be tilted, and you must plan for it.

When the government controls the Assembly. The parliamentary lever is weaker. Lean harder on the environmental, international, and court levers, and carry the fight toward the ballot box, where the parliament is decided.

When the motives are mixed. Environment and sovereignty both drive such fights. Name both honestly, and draw strength from both, without pretending one was the whole.

When the outcome is gradual. Assumption's deal lingered before it died, and a foreign presence remained. Judge success by whether the destructive project is stopped, and keep watching.

When a foreign power is a partner. Raise the sovereignty and environmental concerns, draw the international eye, and turn the parliament — the levers a foreign backer's power doesn't reach.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Seychelles has real concerns about opaque deals and the closeness of powerful interests, so this matters.

How to spot it. Agreements made with little openness; authorisations against the evidence; benefits to the connected while a pristine place bears the harm.

Who's supposed to guard against it. The **Auditor General** and the **Anti-Corruption Commission** examine public money and conduct. The **National Assembly** scrutinises agreements and can refuse them. The **courts** can quash a tainted authorisation. And Seychelles' **press and civil society** have exposed captured deals.

How to fight it safely. Document precisely and factually — how the deal was made, who benefits, what the law required — and keep clear the line between what you can prove and what you suspect. Route serious evidence to the Auditor General, the Anti-Corruption Commission, the Assembly, the courts, and trusted journalists rather than making accusations you can't back. Pair the exposure with the parliamentary and international levers.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together. The documents build your proof; the protected place aims it; a mobilised public is the muscle; the Assembly, the international bodies, and the courts press the case; the press and the world's eye raise the cost. Together they multiply. One at a time, they stall.

Early on (weeks 1–8): establish the ratification requirement and the parliament's composition; mobilise the public around the protected place; object in the EIA; alert the international bodies; build the coalition.

In the thick of it (weeks–months): turn the Assembly against ratification; invoke the protected-place status; challenge a defective authorisation; open the national and international media front.

The long haul (months–years): hold the pressure; where the parliament can't be turned, carry the fight to the ballot box; hold the line for a project stopped, a deal killed, a place protected, and delay.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Stopping a destructive project in Seychelles can be done — a mobilised public and a parliament that refused to ratify stopped a foreign-backed military base beside a World Heritage atoll. Hold both truths. The Seychelles' distinctive power is real: a public that defends a pristine, protected place, an international eye that a government cannot ignore, and — decisively — a National Assembly whose ratification a project needs and can be made to withhold. And the constraints are real: the parliamentary lever depends on who holds the Assembly, the motives in such fights are often mixed, and the outcome can be a gradual shelving rather than a clean cancellation.

Here's the discipline that wins. Establish whether the project needs the Assembly's ratification — and if it does, make that your sharpest lever, turning the parliament against it with the pressure of a mobilised public and the cause of a threatened place. Defend the protected or World Heritage place, and draw the international eye that supplies the weight. Take part in the EIA and challenge a defective authorisation in the courts. Name the mixed motives — environment and sovereignty — honestly, and draw strength from both. And where the government controls the Assembly, carry the fight toward the ballot box, because that is where the parliamentary lever is decided. Count a project stopped, a deal killed, a place protected, and delay as wins. That's what Assumption did — the place, the public, the world's eye, and the parliament together. So can you.